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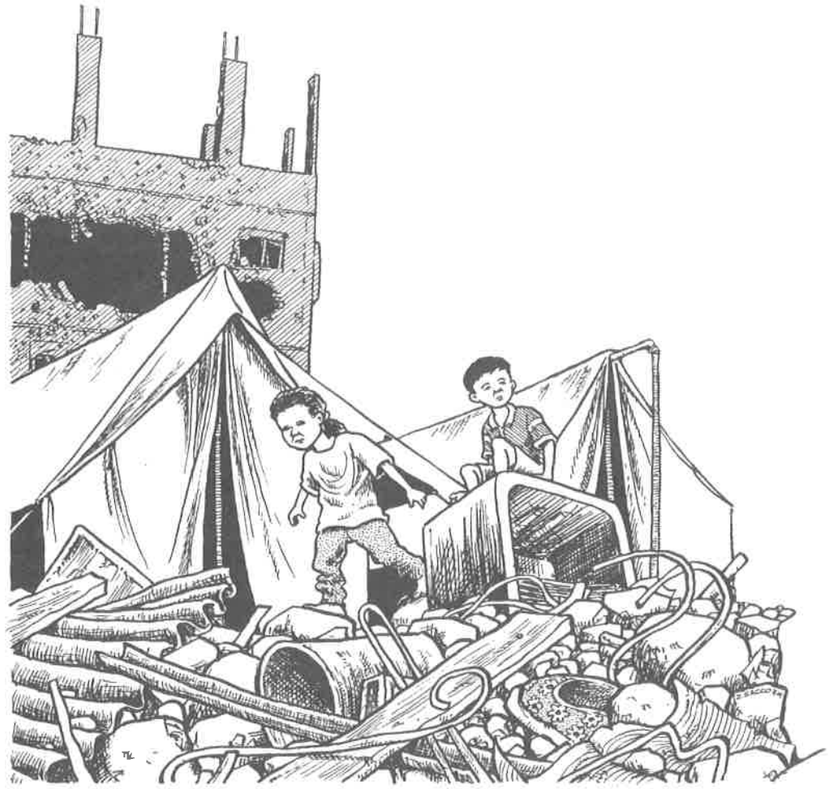

Jonathan Cape
London

WORLD

HEBRON: A LOOK INSIDE

An evil electricity crackles through the West Bank town—the sparks that arise when two peoples who hate each other rub together. TIME sent comic journalist Joe Sacco there for two weeks. He captured this fresh, provocative view

Colors by Rhea Patton

The taxis bringing us to Hebron can go no farther.

We jump out and make a run for the earthen barricade the Israelis have laid across the main road to hinder the movement of Palestinians.

We're lucky, says my guide Salem, 'cause usually Israeli soldiers are here to harass the people, but who wants to be out in this muck?

There's a slippery dash for taxis on the other side.

By the time we find one with room, 10 minutes later, we're soaked.

But the way to Hebron is now clear.

Hebron is the West Bank's most contentious town, the only one that's divided, the only one with Jewish settlers—who began to establish themselves in the late 1960's—living cheek by jowl with Palestinians.

In peace process-speak, the Palestinian Authority controls H1, 80% of Hebron; the Israeli military controls the rest, H2.

Let's face it, you have to be ultracommitted to move your family to the heart of a town whose 120,000 residents loathe you, and spokesman David Wilder and the 500 or so other Hebron settlers are just that. Originally from New Jersey, Wilder says it's "perhaps the climax of returning to one's roots" for a Jew to live here.

NEAR THE TEL RUMEIDA SETTLEMENT, H2

THIS IS WHERE ABRAHAM SETTLED...

THIS IS WHERE KING DAVID BEGAN HIS KINGDOM BEFORE HE WENT TO JERUSALEM...

SOMEWHERE UNDER OUR FEET ARE THE ORIGINAL GATES OF HEBRON!

In the Israeli zone, the Tomb of the Patriarchs, Judaism's second holiest site, is underneath the Haram al-Khalil, Islam's fourth holiest place. For 700 years, until Israel occupied the West Bank in 1967, Jews were not allowed to worship inside. "If we were not here," says Wilder, "no Jew would get anywhere close to it."

"It's not a holy site for Jews," insists Nizar Ramadan, a writer associated with Hebron's fundamentalist Islamic movement. He says Israeli-imposed curfews and the other restrictions that often keep Muslim worshippers from the Haram are a "deep discrimination and a new kind of Nazism."

Many Palestinians charge the armed settlers and the soldiers who guard them with abuse and assault. Wilder charges back, "The Arabs are extremely good at lying."

In his view, it's the settlers—in their fortified compounds—who are under siege.

Jews had coexisted with Arabs in Hebron for hundreds of years until shortly after a massacre of 67 Jews by Arabs in 1929, and without the large Israeli army garrison to protect them now—

BEIT HADASSAH COMPOUND, H2

THERE WOULD BE A BLOODBATH HERE.

When shots are fired from H1 at the settlers, Israel punishes the 40,000 Palestinians under its control in H2 with a curfew.

The curfew can last months at a time, with breaks of a few hours only every few days.

The curfew prevents Majed Natshe from getting to his sweets shop job in H1. He's lost all his savings, he says.

SOMETIMES I BREAK THE CURFEW TO GO TO WORK...

AND TO GET NECESSARY THINGS FOR THE CHILDREN, DRUGS FOR MY MOTHER.

ALSO, MY WIFE IS PREGNANT. SHE HAS BASIC NEEDS.

He's been shot at three times while breaking the curfew in the back streets of H2, he says.

Wilder says the curfew is the—

PRICE PAID FOR WHAT THEY ARE DOING...

A CURFEW DOESN'T ENDANGER ANYBODY'S LIFE. THE BULLETS THEY ARE SHOOTING AT US DO...

Other bullets, February 1994: Mohammed Abu Ilhalaweh, a father of four, was at the Haram al-Khalil mosque when settler Dr. Baruch Goldstein from nearby Kiryat Arba walked in and killed 29 worshippers.

A gruesome photo on the wall reminds Abu Ilhalaweh of the bullet that paralyzed him that day, but—

THE CASUALTIES OF THE PAST ARE NO LONGER ACKNOWLEDGED.

NOBODY CARES FOR OUR NEEDS BECAUSE THERE ARE NEW CASUALTIES, NEW VICTIMS...

and more than 30 "martyrs" in Hebron so far in this intifadeh.

At the University Graduates Union in H1, I take a sweet from a large bowl and then shake hands with a man whose teenage son was killed by Israeli soldiers three or four days earlier. I'm steered to the front, between rows of men drinking bitter coffee and listening to the exhortations of one speaker after another. Eventually dozens of masked youths march in and face the crowd.

Someone leans over and says, "In America when someone dies, you cry. Here we have a party."

The settlers mourn too. Wilder tells me his daughter's teacher, from another settlement, was killed on a road just outside Hebron. Settlers are sandbagging their windows.

IT'S LIKE LIVING IN A BUNKER.

We're back on the bullets. I'm shown where they've hit settlers' homes.

One bullet entered a bedroom in the Tel Rumeida trailer of Bracha Ben Yitzhak where four of her children were sleeping.

IT'S A MIRACLE THAT NOTHING HAPPENED BECAUSE THE ARABS ARE TRYING TO KILL US.

IT'S WAR HERE.

RESULTS OF ISRAELI FIRE ON THE HARET AL-SHEIKH NEIGHBORHOOD, H1

If it's war, the settlers aren't satisfied with how the Israeli army is conducting it. When you're being shot at "from a particular source night after night, what do you do?" asks Wilder. "You level the house! Very simple to do... And they don't do it."

I tell Wilder I've visited Palestinian homes hit by Israeli fire. Civilians live in them. "But they're shooting from those homes," he insists. If the Israeli army is hitting homes, its spokesman Lieut. Colonel Olivier Rasowicz claims, "we are very careful and very accurate and only responding to the source of fire."

Yasser Qawasmi's home was raked by Israeli bullets. He denies it was a "source of fire." He says his children now have nightmares.

THIS ONE IS WETTING THE BED...

AND NOW HE'S WETTING HIS CLOTHES TOO, EVEN IN THE DAYTIME.

J. SACCO 1.01

Palestinians in Hebron have been killed in their homes. Fatina al-Fokhouri was wounded.

I WAS CARRYING THE BABY, AND MY HUSBAND GOT THE OTHER THREE KIDS. AS WE TRIED TO GO DOWNSTAIRS, THE FRAGMENTS HIT ME IN THE FOREHEAD AND FLEW OVER MY BODY.

With one of the only English words he knows, her husband Sharif invites me to inspect where Israeli projectiles have punched through the walls.

WELCOME!

WELCOME!

Through an interpreter, I ask him if his home, which houses his extended family, was used by gunmen to shoot at the settlers.

WE HAVE 30 CHILDREN IN THIS HOUSE.

I WOULDN'T ALLOW ANYONE TO SHOOT FROM HERE EVEN IF IT WOULD LIBERATE AL-AQSA MOSQUE!

Some of the positions from which Israeli troops fire are forcibly seized Palestinian rooftops in H2.

"We have to be where we have to be to prevent violence from the other side," Rasowicz says.

Israeli soldiers are on Izzi al-Sharabati's roof. He claims they've dumped garbage, urine and excrement on the rest of his house. He says this ceiling is crumbling because soldiers were moving and firing a heavy machine gun on top.

When he complained to the Israelis—

THEY SAID, THANK YOU FOR INFORMING US ABOUT THE DANGER... AND THEY MOVED TO THE OTHER SIDE OF THE ROOF!

WHY DON'T THEY PUT THIS MILITARY POSITION ON THE ROOFS OF THE SETTLERS?

THEY USE US AS A SANDBAG FOR THEIR PROTECTION!

Attached as the settlers are to Hebron, any eventual peace deal will probably mean uprooting them. How? "Military force," predicts Amiram Goldblum, who tracks settlements for the Israeli protest movement Peace Now.

THERE ARE THOSE WHO ARE TRYING TO FORCE US OUT, BE IT VIA POLITICAL MEANS... OR VIOLENCE, HOPING THAT PEOPLE WILL GIVE UP AND LEAVE. WE HAVE NO INTENTION OF DOING THAT.

THIS IS OUR HOME.

Meanwhile, Abu Ilhalaweh says his home is only half a kilometer from the grave of Dr. Baruch Goldstein, who was bludgeoned to death at the scene of the mosque attack. He says on the anniversary of Goldstein's crime and other occasions, settlers gather at the grave.

FROM THE ROAD WE CAN SEE THEM CELEBRATING.

WE HEAR MUSIC FROM UP THERE...

THEY SHOUT, "WHERE ARE YOU, GOLDSTEIN?"

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GAZA PORTFOLIO

Sabha Abu Mousa searched for her daughter-in-law's two gold bracelets in the rubble of her home, which was demolished by the Israel Defense Forces, in the Khan Younis refugee camp.

Khan Younis refugee camp (left)

The Israeli checkpoint at Abu Houli that divided Khan Younis and the southern Gaza Strip from the north (below)

Palestinian fishermen cut off from the Mowasi enclave (which contained a Jewish settlement bloc) by an Israeli closure were unable to operate or maintain their boats and equipment for months.

The Underground War in Gaza

As the peace process lurches forward (and backward), towns like Rafah are still at war. A comic-book journalist reports on the battle over Palestinian tunnels and Israeli bulldozers.

By Joe Sacco

In Rafah, talk of the "road map to peace" and of moving the Israeli-Palestinian conflict toward a resolution is drowned out by the sounds of bulldozing and machine-gun fire. Rafah—whose 105,000 residents are overwhelmingly refugees—is one of the most militant Palestinian towns, hemmed in on two sides by Jewish settlements and by an Israeli-controlled security zone along the border. The Israel Defense Forces (I.D.F.) considers Rafah its most active "front."

Rafah's particular curse—some might say distinction—is that it serves as an entry point for weapons to the Gaza Strip's militants via a system of tunnels from Egypt, some of which are hundreds of yards long and up to 100 feet deep.

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J. SACCO 6-03

O.K., I say, let's talk about the destruction of one particular home. It belonged to someone I know—let's call him T.—and it was demolished not four days before, along with a few other dwellings.

Colonel Avi knows the houses. He says gunmen used them as cover to shoot at a bulldozer.

YOU CALL THIS A HOME, WE CALL THIS A MILITARY POSITION.

IT'S AN EMPTY HOME, A VACANT HOME THAT NO FAMILY IS LIVING IN.

The I.D.F. claim that houses demolished are mostly "empty" may be technically accurate, but Palestinians say that it turns the truth on its head. For example, T.'s home was "empty"—but only, he says, because he and his family were chased out by constant Israeli gunfire.

He visited his "empty" house every day, he says, and recently bricked it up so that gunmen couldn't use it.

The Israelis have succeeded in driving a wedge between the people living near the border and the gunmen. Though Palestinians here support the resistance in general, I've heard the gunmen called "useless," even "collaborators," because their ineffective attacks often invite a crushing Israeli response.

I've seen armed men chased off by a man who didn't want them lurking near his house.

Keeping the gunmen out is the "main reason" Fuad stays in his family home near the border despite the entreaties of his parents. The Israelis, he says—

—DON'T NEED AN EXCUSE TO DEMOLISH YOUR HOUSE. BUT THEY CAN USE THE GUNMEN AS A REASON.

While his watchful presence in his home would seem to satisfy the interests of the I.D.F., he says Israeli bullets still hit the house randomly. (I was present during one incident.) Palestinians typically interpret that message as an injunction to flee.

As for the tunnels, the reaction of Sami and his neighbors is precisely what the I.D.F. may have intended all along.

He shows me a tunnel entrance that they had completely blocked up with rubble.

WE DESTROYED THIS HOUSE BECAUSE OF A TUNNEL.

Sami says he and his neighbors "attacked" the smugglers who started this tunnel and chased them away.

He claims a smuggler offered him $60,000 to use his house to build a tunnel—

—AND I REALIZED IT WOULD NOT BE FOR GUNS OR WEAPONS, BUT FOR DRUGS.

I COULD HAVE BEEN A RICH MAN IN ONE NIGHT.

But he says he wants nothing to do with the smugglers. He doesn't want to give the Israelis an excuse to destroy his home.

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But even so, he can't be sure it will be spared. He says he believes the Israelis are using the issue of tunnels to extend the area they control along the border.

On the edge of Block J, he points to a site where the Israelis found a tunnel—

—150 METERS FROM HERE! SO WHY DID THEY DESTROY THIS WHOLE AREA?

One Palestinian militant I talk to admits that the I.D.F. has been about "90 percent successful" in its efforts to destroy tunnels, but:

NOW WE ARE NOT SO DEPENDENT ON THE TUNNELS AND ON EGYPT.

WITH A FEW MATERIALS AVAILABLE HERE, SUGAR, FOR EXAMPLE, OR FERTILIZER, I CAN CREATE VERY POWERFUL EXPLOSIVE MATERIAL.

He tells me Palestinians are even manufacturing bullets—not as good as "Russian" bullets, he says, but bullets just the same.

I ask Colonel Pinky when the demolitions in Rafah will stop. When "there is no resistance and there is no shooting," he says. "We want the tunnels to be stopped."

All things considered, he characterizes the Israeli response to Palestinian resistance and the tunnels as "gentle, if you can say gentle about something like this." If I wanted to see an army without restraint, he says, I should "go to Chechnya."

Such distinctions may be lost on the 5,300 people Unrwa says have lost their homes here. But T. doesn't seem bitter yet about the destruction of the house that he says he "spent all my life dreaming about."

In fact, after agonizing for weeks as the bulldozers drew nearer, he seems almost relieved now that the deed is done.

YES, BEFORE I HAD HOPE, BUT NOW IT'S FINISHED.

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Incidentally, when I returned to Block O to look up the woman who had asked me what I would do in her place, I didn't find her.

The whole row of houses, including hers, was gone.

The Palestinian Territories, Notes

I think of "Hebron: A Look Inside," which appeared in *Time* magazine, as my least successful piece of comics journalism. I cannot blame the senior editor, Joshua Cooper Ramo, who took a chance on comics journalism and supported me every step of the way. Working for that storied publication seemed to freeze me up, and I dispensed with my more typical first-person approach and reverted to the objective, tit-for-tat reporting I'd learned in journalism school. For this reason, I failed to adequately convey the great unfairness of making the free movement of tens of thousands of Palestinians hostage to the considerations of the few hundred militant Jewish settlers.

"Gaza Portfolio" includes both published and unpublished drawings meant to accompany an article my friend and colleague Chris Hedges wrote about Khan Younis, a town and refugee camp in the Gaza Strip. We sold ourselves as a team to Lewis Lapham, editor of *Harper's Magazine* at the time, and he commissioned our weeklong trip to Gaza. Unfortunately, I don't think Mr. Lapham appreciated what I could possibly add to Chris's article with drawings, and he seemed dissatisfied with the ones that showed human faces. I was put off by his second-guessing and almost abandoned the project. As it was, the few drawings published were printed so small as to induce further despair.

I consider "The Underground War in Gaza" a successful project even though, like the *Time* piece about Hebron, I was given only four pages. Representing the *New York Times Magazine* opened doors for me at the Israeli Foreign Press Office, and Israeli spokespersons asked if I would like to spend a day and night with Israel Defense Forces soldiers manning their positions along the Egyptian border. That opportunity allowed me to convey Israeli concerns about weapons smuggling while still questioning the enormous scale of the IDF's home-demolition campaign. Readers of my book *Footnotes in Gaza* might note that the "T" character whose home had just been demolished is Talal, the father of Ashraf, one of that book's main protagonists. Though I have nothing but good things to say about the editor who commissioned the piece, Paul Tough, the story passed through many hands, and there was some effort to get me to comply with the abbreviation commandments of the *New York Times* style guide. Additionally, I had to assure one editor that the background crosshatching on the second panel of the story's last page was not an effort to slip in a lot of little crucifixes.

"Hebron: A Look Inside" appeared in *Time*, March 12, 2001.

Only two of the illustrations shown in "Gaza Portfolio" ("The Khan Younis refugee camp" and "The Israeli checkpoint...") accompanied the article by Chris Hedges, "A Gaza Diary," in *Harper's Magazine*, October 2001; one illustration, "Sabha Abu Mousa...", appeared in a revised form (without the female figure); none of the other illustrations were used.

"The Underground War in Gaza" appeared in the *New York Times Magazine*, July 6, 2003.

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